

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Construction and Architecture English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For architects, construction managers, project engineers, site supervisors, estimators, owners' representatives, subcontractor coordinators, and design-build teams.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

allowance

An amount included in a construction budget for an item not yet fully specified.

change order

A documented modification to agreed construction work, often affecting price or time.

claim

A statement that may need evidence, approval, qualification, or disclosure before it is used externally.

closeout

The documented completion and transfer of a project's remaining obligations and records.

code compliance

Conformity with the applicable building, engineering, or other technical code requirements.

constructability

Extent to which a design can be built safely, efficiently, and reliably using available methods, materials, and sequencing.

contingency

A possible future condition or provision for it; in contracts, a condition affecting the transaction.

critical path

Sequence of dependent work that determines the shortest feasible timeline.

daily report

A dated record of work, conditions, events, or progress during a day.

design intent

Functional, aesthetic, performance, and user objectives the design must preserve as details are developed.

drawing set

The collection of drawings that describes a design or construction project.

entitlement

A right to a benefit or remedy under applicable rules or an agreement.

fall protection

Systems and measures used under approved procedures to address the risk of falls from height.

float

The amount a scheduled activity can move without delaying a specified project milestone under the schedule model.

inspection

An examination of an item or condition against relevant requirements.

lookahead schedule

A detailed plan for work expected in the near term.

meeting minutes

A written record of key discussion points, decisions, and agreed actions.

notice

A formal communication informing a party about an event, requirement, or proposed action.

permit

Official permission for an activity under specified requirements.

PPE

Personal protective equipment selected and used under applicable task-specific safety requirements.

program

In architecture, a statement of required spaces, functions, and user needs; elsewhere, an organized set of activities.

punch list

A list of outstanding construction items requiring completion or correction.

reinspection

An additional inspection, often to check correction of previously identified issues.

resequencing

Changing the planned order of activities.

RFI

Request for information used to resolve an ambiguity, conflict, or missing detail in contract documents or a project scope.

scope

Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

specification

A detailed statement of required characteristics, performance, or materials.

stop work

A call or authorized action to pause work when a safety concern requires attention under local procedures.

submittal

Information supplied by a contractor for required review, such as product data or shop drawings.

substantial completion

A contract-defined construction stage when work is sufficiently complete for its intended use, subject to applicable terms.

toolbox talk

A short, task-relevant safety discussion conducted under an organization's safety arrangements.

warranty

A promise or contractual assurance about a product or work, with defined terms and remedies.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Design Intent and Client Requirements

A client describes a meeting space as "flexible" but has not specified occupancy, furniture changes, or audiovisual needs.

What activities should the space support, and how often will the layout change? Let's clarify occupancy and equipment needs so the design brief gives the team a usable direction.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Drawings, Specifications, and RFIs

A drawing and specification appear to describe different finishes for the same area. The site team needs a documented clarification.

Could the design team confirm the intended finish and relevant revision? I'll identify the conflicting references in a request for information rather than assume which instruction takes precedence.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

03 | Change Orders and Cost Control

A client requests an additional partition after pricing is agreed. Cost and schedule effects have not been assessed.

We can review the partition as a proposed change. Let's assess its cost and schedule effect through the agreed change process before confirming that it is included in the current price.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

04 | Schedule, Sequencing, and Critical Path

A delivery delay affects a task on the current critical path. A lookahead schedule still shows the original sequence.

The delayed delivery affects a critical-path task. I'll update the lookahead and show the feasible resequencing options for review instead of leaving the original dates unexplained.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

05 | Site Safety and Toolbox Talks

In a toolbox-talk exercise, an instruction says to use "the right protection" without identifying the task or approved requirement.

Which task and approved safety requirement does this refer to? Please have the authorized person clarify the instruction before work proceeds. The language needs to be specific enough to understand and check.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

06 | Permitting, Inspections, and Code Issues

An inspection note identifies outstanding items, but a progress email says the area is fully approved.

Could you confirm the inspection status and the items still outstanding? I'll correct the progress wording so it does not imply approval that has not been documented.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Quality, Punch List, and Closeout

A closeout list contains eight items, with three completed and five awaiting review. The incoming coordinator needs the supporting records.

Three items are complete, and five await review. The list links each item to its record and responsible party. Please confirm the remaining review steps before reporting closeout as finished.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

08 | Claims, Disputes, and Documentation

A project team wants to say a delay automatically entitles it to compensation. The contract and records have not been reviewed.

The delay and its effects should be documented, but entitlement requires appropriate contract and legal review. I'll separate the factual record from any conclusion about a claim.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.